

Alan Schaller: light and shadow



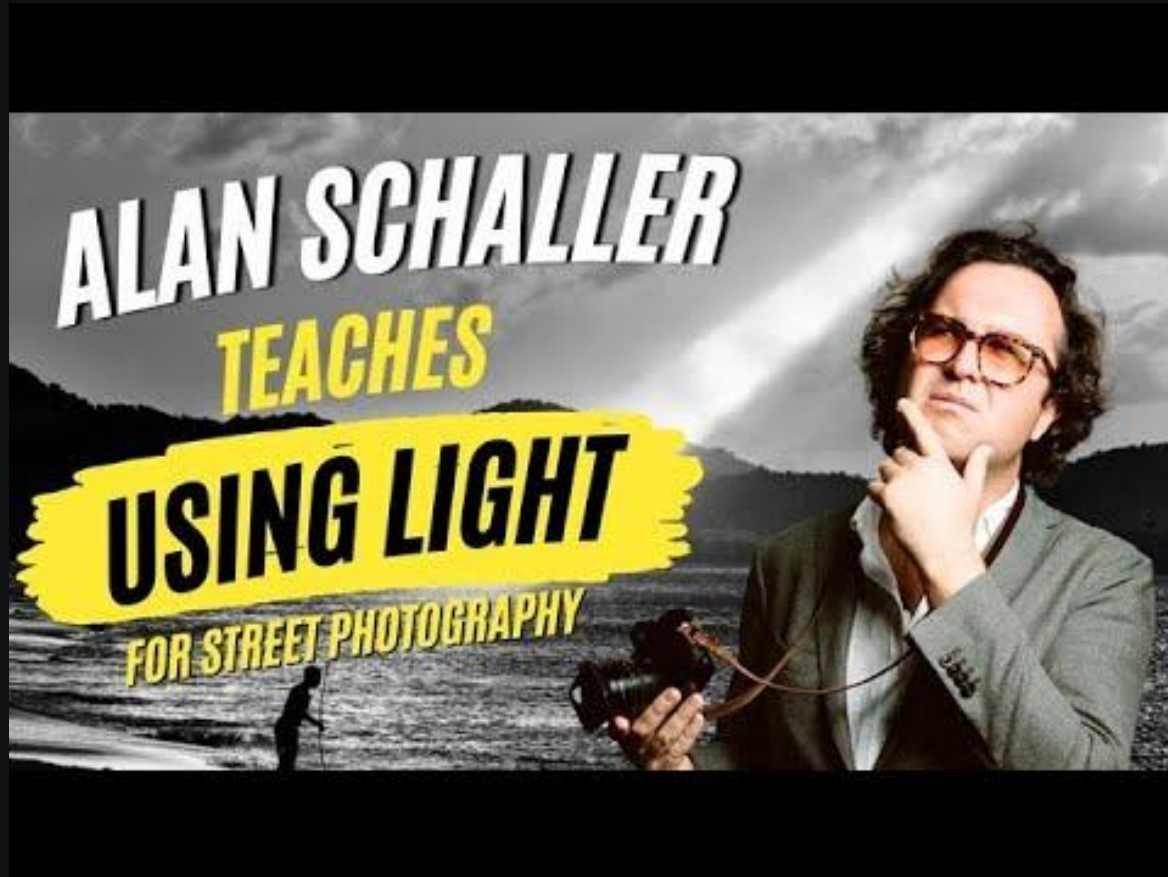
Photograph © Alan Schaller / Metropolis

**London-based
photographer**

Known for black-and-white
street photographs with
bold shapes and strong
light.

**Today: make one subject
stand out.**

Watch how he uses the light



[PLAY THE FULL VIDEO ↗](#)

Where is the light?

Where does he stand?

Why make it darker?

A bright background reveals the outline



**The person is dark
against a lighter wall.**

WHY IT HELPS

The change from dark to light makes the person easy to find.

Silhouette = a dark outline.

Leave dark space around the subject



Photograph © Alan Schaller / Metropolis

ALAN SCHALLER / LIGHT AND SHADOW

**A small bright area
can hold our
attention.**

WHY IT HELPS

The dark surroundings
remove competing detail.
Lit pavement and figures
stand out.

**Contrast = difference in
light and dark.**

Three directions of light

FRONT LIGHT

Light behind the photographer.

It lights the front of the subject.
Useful for clear, visible detail.

SIDE LIGHT

Light beside the subject.

One side is brighter than the other.
This helps show shape.

BACKLIGHT

Light behind the subject.

A bright background can reveal
a dark outline or glowing edge.

Try a mug beside a window

SIMPLE WINDOW SETUP



ILLUSTRATIVE RESULT



1 Put a mug beside a window.

2 Aim the phone at the mug.
Keep the darker room behind it.

3 Keep the window to one side.

WHY: A bright side and a dark side make the mug look rounded.

AI-generated setup and result; not an Alan Schaller photograph.

Exposure changes picture brightness

WHAT TO DO

WHY IT HELPS

Start with the normal photo.

This gives you something to compare.

Lower camera exposure a little.

The whole photograph gets darker.

Keep detail in the bright side.

The mug should still look rounded.

Stop before the subject disappears.

A dark background works best when it was already darker than the subject.

A small change is enough. There is no single correct number.

iPhone: take the photograph

WHAT TO DO

WHY IT HELPS

Choose Photo mode and 1×.

A normal still photo using the main camera is a simple starting point.

Turn the flash off.

Keep the window light and shadows.

Tap the mug or person on screen.

Focus chooses what looks sharp.

Drag the sun control down slightly.

Keep detail in the bright side as the background becomes darker.

Hold steady. Compare a normal photo with a slightly darker one.

Android: take the photograph

WHAT TO DO

WHY IT HELPS

Choose Photo mode and 1×.

Use a normal still photo and the main camera where available.

Turn the flash off.

Keep the window light and shadows.

Tap the mug or person on screen.

Focus chooses what looks sharp.

Find Brightness / Exposure.
Move toward darker or minus.

Lower image brightness a little.
Keep detail in the bright side.

Samsung: Camera quick controls → Exposure, where available.

Make a black-and-white copy

Black and white uses shades of gray.

SATURATION = COLOUR STRENGTH

Lower Saturation all the way
to remove colour.

WHY REMOVE COLOUR?

We notice light, shadow
and shape more clearly.

iPhone: Photos → picture → Edit → Adjust → Saturation

Android: photo editor → Edit → colour / Saturation

Menu names vary. Save a copy where available.

Edit only enough to show the subject

HIGHLIGHTS

The brightest parts.

Lower a little if the lit mug looks blank white.

SHADOWS

The darkest parts.

Lower for a darker backdrop.
Raise if useful detail disappears.

CONTRAST

Difference between light and dark.

Raise gently to separate shapes.
Too much can hide detail.

Optional: choose one photo to try

SIDE-LIT OBJECT

Put a mug, flower or toy by a window.
Keep a darker room behind it.
Try a slightly darker exposure.

Photograph it during daylight.

PERSON AND SHADOW

Ask a family member to stand where sunlight meets shade.
Include their shadow in the frame.

Try early or late sunlight.

Make a black-and-white copy. Compare it with your colour original.